Keith Dunstan, journalist, author, cyclist, raconteur and wine buff, joins 'Melbourne Living' to begin a weekly column.

When even women are human



TO GIVE you the real truth, I am a somewhat failed Anglican.

Oh God, it's hard to get it out of one's system. Particularly when you are born into an Anglican household, went to an Anglican school and had an awesome Anglican bishop lay on hands at confirmation.

Now I get to church maybe one Sunday out of two. During the sermon there is time for a look around and meditation. You could say that on average women outnumber the men four to one.

You could say that with canvassing, sewing, making the coffee and scones, fixing the fete, cleaning the brass, mending the kneelers, writing the parish paper, women do 90 per cent of the work.

The organisation that can make a canon or even an archdeacon tremble is the Mothers' Union. Yet it has never learnt to organise itself like a union. Should a Norma Gallagher get in there, should a Joanna Halfpenny take command, they could crack the Anglican communion.

What if they had a four-week strike, didn't put their envelopes in the plate for a whole month? They could have female priests in St Andrew's and St Paul's cathedrals faster than you could crack a wafer.

I don't know what goes on in the Catholic Church, but from what I see among my Irish mates, latent female power there is even more intimidating. If Norma and Joanna got in there nothing would stop them until they had lady cardinals and enthroned Pope Paula 1.

Oh, make no mistake, female power is on its way. It is about eight years since we won the first vestrywoman at our church. There were complaints a-plenty. Vestry meetings from now on would become a hen's party. As if they weren't already.

As it turned out the vestrywomen were a tremendous asset because they knew what was going on, and, after all, it was a female church.

Soon after that we had lay people administering the chalice at holy communion. The vicar, with courage that deserved the VC, decided that one of the women should do it.

I think it was the shock of this event that started the rock crumbling on the bell tower. There were some old priests who could barely face approaching the altar rail . . . the blood of Christ from a woman!!!

We have female churchwardens all around the diocese, so, too, are they represented on the encumbency committees, which have the task of finding any new vicar. But you just wait, the time will come when female power will take over those committees altogether and only elect their own kind.

I don't know why we loathe women so much, but it has a long history in Australia. Partly it has been the carrying on of an English tradition where always after dinner the females were dismissed so that the men could carry on a sensible discourse alone. But we developed the idea, discovered a mystic thing called "mateship".

Sidney J. Baker, the great authority on the Australian language, said mateship was a feeling of mutual dependence bred into the Australian soul. It came out of the female shortage, beginning with the convict days, then the Gold Rush, then the era of strikes and depressions. The mateship thing went on in two world wars and continued to bear fruit through Anzac Day. There were always strong homosexual overtones to it, and the redoubtable Sid Baker even offered evidence that Ned Kelly was gay.

So the theory developed that we could not stand females. Women, after all, were a different species. They rarely talked about sensible things like football, racing and the quality of beer. It was better if they were separated at schools from an early age. Pure bliss was the all-male haven such as the RSL.

I grew up in an era of complete sexual apartheid. Our hotel bars were totally monastic until the early 1970s. Even as late as 1969 the unescorted lady was something to be feared. When granting a licence for a new St Kilda caberet, Judge O'Driscoll warned the nominee: "The commission will not tolerate women attending without an escort."

But look, things are moving. We are letting them into sacred areas of our racecouses now. We are allowing them the ultimate honor of putting them on the backs of horses. Then two years ago, under threats from the Premier of Victoria, we allowed them in as members of the Melbourne Cricket Club, right into the holy of holies, the Long Room.

Frankly, I thought this was going too far. The sight of a bare female leg could break one's concentration when trying to pick Mr Alderman's outswinger or when thrashing one's memory trying to recall whether Mr Wessels had really set a world record for an eighth-wicket partnership for a sunny Tuesday in November.

Females there among the holiest of cricket relics belonging to W.G., Ponsford and Bradman; yet we survived and now at the approach of a skirt older members barely raise their noses from their chests.

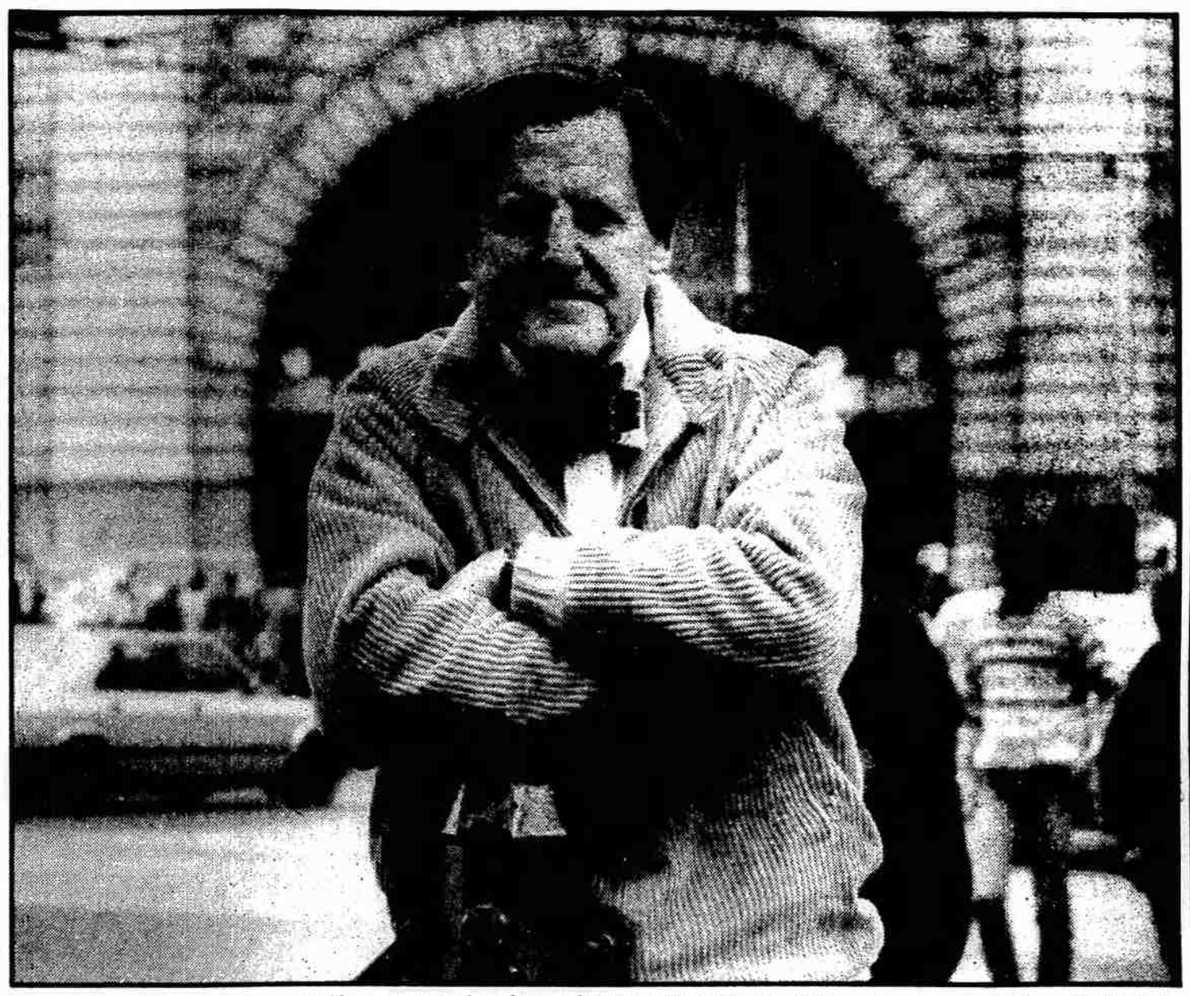
So I would suggest we give in now. Let the females take over as bishops, priests, archdeacons, canons and the full range of artillery. The Anglican Church can only prosper.

Some theologians claim it can't be done. They claim God created the female unclean and because of the menstrual cycle the priesthood is not for them.

I don't think they really know what is going on in 1985.

If they can even tell the difference between male and female priests at the altar rail I'll be surprised. They will find that the female priests are the ones with the short hair.

— Keith Dunstan



Keith Dunstan: "I don't know why we loathe women so much . . ." Picture: MIKE MARTIN

Parslow Personified



Picture: ROGER CUMMINS

Frederick Parslow: "Joan and I should never have married each other . . . because we collect things."

At home

JUDITH WOODFALL

FREDERICK Parslow, the actor, sits opposite me in his study, totally ignoring the mayhem around him. They've got the builders in — the whistling, sawing variety.

He says: "Joan's always wanted a walk-in pantry."

Parslow plays the role he has played the longest: himself. He is a man without affectation and conceit and a lifetime of audiences staring at him has cured him of any habits he might have had such as sniffing or fiddling with his hair.

He sits relaxed, his legs crossed, smoking and chatting. He has a matinee shortly and the only evidence that he is going to work is a trace of make-up on his hands and face. I ask him if he has lunch before the performance. "No. I have a sandwich or something in the dressingroom," he says. "I hate going on stage feeling full. I think I work better slightly hungry.

"August, 30 years ago, was when I first joined the Melbourne Theatre Company, but I've been away for periods of five years at a time. I spent five years working constantly in television — it was at a period when 'In Melbourne Tonight' was on Channel 9. And I really think that that time, when Kennedy was there and Colin Bednall was running it, was the heyday. We did a lot of outside filming and we had a brilliant writer, Jeff Underhill, and he wrote wonderfully satirical stuff for us."

Parslow lights another cigarette and continues: "When I first started with the MTC it was a small company and you were given roles to do whether you were suited to them or not. So it made actors a bit adventurous I think and they were willing to have a go. I think some actors nowadays are a bit protective of themselves and regard themselves as a particular sort of actor: that's okay if that sort of actor is required, but more often than not they're *not*, and they're out of work and they complain."

Parslow, his wife Joan Harris, the talented director of the National Theatre Drama School, their 18-year-old son Justin, and Joan Harris's 87-year-old mother, who has a separate apartment in their home, live in a solid, middle-class area in a comfortable 1920s single-storey biscuit-colored, brick, cement-rendered home with bay windows, still with their original beautiful leadlight, overlooking the front garden. The front veranda is red-brick and there are healthy orchids, palms, balsam, and ferns in pots. He says: "If I'm working around the garden I'll perhaps have two or three cigarettes reward for what I've done . . . We're mad, completely mad to smoke."

He wears shiny black boots, black trousers, a black, lightweight wool v-necked jumper and a self-patterned, blue, silk, open-necked shirt. Almost as much as our appearance, our voice is an indication of who and what we are: and Parslow's voice is impressive, courteous and in complete control.

I tell him my only venture on to the stage was when I was about five; it was the end of the war, and I was conscripted into singing 'On the Good Ship Lollipop', with feet accompaniment, for the war effort. I took one look at the audience and fled. I was pushed back on to my Uncle Stan's back veranda with my brother for moral support, and I sang with my back to the audience. My feet remained stationary.

With that grim theatrical history, I am stage-struck by someone who can not only face people but does it every night — with the additional nightmare of matinees.

Such a person is Frederick Parslow.

Brought up in Shepparton, he was a teller with the Commercial Bank. He says: "I got myself transferred to Melbourne . . . and I got busy and studied acting.

"There is no theatrical history in the family at all. My mother *completely* gave me away and didn't talk to me for three years. My father had quite a good singing voice and he was a marvellous storyteller — I used to love sitting around the fire at home with him and he'd tell me stories, literally about the pioneer days. He was a Victorian, he was a fascinating man, loved to chat. He was more like a grandfather to me, he would have been in his fifties when I was born. He was a very, very kind father, and he was always good for money if I wanted money — I would never go *near* my mother."

He continues, ignoring a buzz saw. "Living in a small country town, there was no drama group there whatsoever. And a Methodist background — it does take a lot of getting over, because in those days they did *not* even approve of dancing."

Parslow looks a cross between a matinee-idol and a trusted banker — even if he did borrow from his father. The awesome experience of a lifetime spent on the stage appears to have done him no harm except that he smokes, and while he doesn't bite his fingernails perhaps he should — they are long. Does he get nervous? "I always think if I'm not working on nervous energy that's when I make mistakes; it's good to have that in the back of your mind — it's a springboard into giving a good performance.

"You don't show it to the audience. The audience thinks you're out there supremely confident — sometimes it's murderous what's going on inside . . . The thing that I get most nervous about is singing. When I went to do 'Die Fledermaus' I can't tell you how nervous I was . . ."

Parslow has worked extensively in theatre, film, television, radio and musical theatre. Some of the plays he has appeared in include 'Auntie Mame', 'Salad Days', 'Rosencrantz and Gildenstern Are Dead', 'The Man who came to Dinner', 'The Floating World', 'Amadeus' and 'Einstein'. He says: "I adored doing Ron Elisha's 'Einstein'. I found him amazing for a young writer. It worked well in America, we had an enchanted stay there. The Americans really celebrated the play; they were on their feet every night. We felt 10 feet tall after every performance."

His films include 'The Last Wave' and 'Alvin Purple' and he has sung in 'Iolanthe' with the Victoria State Opera. He works in radio: "I do a lot of voice-overs; I do book readings on the ABC. I love doing the book readings — they have a very wide listening audience — if I do enough of them I might retire!"

He continues: "I always say I'll get around to directing when my facility fails. Quite a few actors are getting into directing now and it's a very good thing because actors, no matter how little acting experience they've had, always make the best directors, I think. They have more insights into what an actor is going through — they're more enjoyable to work with because they know much of what an actor is up against, and they have more feeling for the work, I think, than somebody who has come from the halls of academia who can be very cold to work with. So-called theatre experts I don't like working with."

Apart from being a talented theatrical married couple for 24 years, the Parslows are, to be blunt, bower-birds of a high order. Parslow says, smiling: "Joan and I should never have married each other, you know, because we collect things . . ."

Their entrance hall is very large and gives an introduction to their avid collecting. There are kilim rugs, paintings by Charles Bush and Julian Smith, and a pianola. "A lot of the pianola rolls are very old sing-a-long things — sometimes we have parties." Rolls include 'All By Yourself in the Moonlight', 'Lilac Time', 'Homesick' and 'Il Trovatore'. On a small table near the pianola are numerous song books including 'Songs of Scotland', 'Three Dances', and 'Songs by Mendelssohn'. There is a fold-down writing desk, those old-fashioned elephants of different sizes, and "a beautiful vase from my grandmother's house". Parslow points to an antique lamp: "That came from Perth. Joan found that and she was heavily pregnant at the time — she came back from shopping with a *treasure*." On the north wall are two samplers: "They're 1847, they're beautiful." On a sideboard is a large vase of banksias. Parslow says: "I love them. I think they're the most extraordinary flowers. You feel as though you could eat them — like an artichoke.

"The carvings came from New Guinea. I went up there about 19 years ago and did a film. It was a beautiful, beautiful place when we were up there, although already stirrings when we were there — cargo cult . . .

"My son taught himself to play on the pianola, he was playing cello. He finished HSC last year, and he's having a bash at acting. He's taken perhaps a year or 18 months off, not to go straight from one school to another . . ." So, at the moment, Justin is courageously following in his father's footsteps.

From the entrance you walk into a large east-facing sittingroom, which is one of the rooms with the lovely leadlight bay windows.

"We love paintings," says Parslow, looking in the direction of a huge canvas. "That was the last one we bought. We've always wanted a country house — we've got a double garage full of furniture for a country house! — and we bought this painting of a country house by Geoffrey Falk."

The sittingroom has an old, soft-floral carpet liberally sprinkled, in the Parslow fashion, with kilims in apricots, navy, red, indigo-blues. There is a brown leather pouffe with a crocheted Afghan throwover on it. In the curve of the bay window is a beautiful circular cedar table encrusted with family photographs and bits and pieces including a ceramic boot. "That was made by one of Joan's students who is a potter," says Parslow. "The whole exhibition was pottery shoes and she kept that one for Joan. It's a pied piper's boot with bells on it."

At the very instant that Frederick Parslow is explaining about having a pied piper's boot on a table his wife comes in looking for her shoes.

There is an open-fireplace, a brass fender and a brass wood bucket. There are stone cats, dogs and a little duck. "Our real cat is called Belle," says Parslow, fondly looking in the direction of a well-fed tabby sitting by the fireplace in a chair, which looks as if it's covered in a William Morris print. There is a low table: "It's a good one for supper, we sit around the fire," and there is a "long sofa table with a collection of small boxes. Joan went through a period of collecting nothing but boxes. I say the only sort of box we haven't got in the house is a coffin".

There is a flame mahogany secretaire: "I'd say it would be early 1800s," says Parslow. "It's German." Sitting on it is one of the many beautiful pieces of pottery they own. "We've got a lot of pottery in the house, done by friends . . ."

In one of their antique bookcases are some of their many books, including the leather-bound 'Gazeteer of Scotland' — "Joan's mother came from Scotland. This is a very old St James prayer book which I found down in Tasmania — leather-bound, the leather is very fragile, and I bought it for ten shillings down there. It was written for the Court of St James."

There are paintings by Phyl Waterhouse and Charles Bush and Moonyeen McNeilage. On the mantelpiece are two large plates: "These were brought back from China by a reverend gentleman, they're very old; it's a lovely faded blue." Belle continues to amiably purr. Parslow says: "She flees in here away from the noise in the kitchen." I look at the cat with renewed respect.

Off the sittingrom is the diningroom which is acting as a storehouse for the kitchen while alterations are in process. It shows great stamina on Parslow's part that he nobly ignores the noise and mess. He points to a dumb waiter: "Joan won that when our son was born. The nuns came around with a raffle." There is a painting by Nonie Gude and another painting by Julian Smith. There is a lovely old cedar chiffonier with a collection of blue and brown and green mugs residing on it. "Three or four of those came from Tasmania," says Parslow, picking up a favorite. "I found them when I was working down there. They're all very, very old. I suspect they came out on sailing ships and I've added to them over the years." There is a cedar bookcase, a huge, long, dining table, "Tasmanian blackwood and it's desperately heavy . . .". Facing south are two leadlight windows and getting a reflection from the light is the Parslow collection of glass animals. They include frogs, dogs, bears, a kangaroo and

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